A Regime Theory of Joy

Childhood Play, Suspended Optimization, and the Ease Regime

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Introduction

Childhood provides a useful starting point for understanding the present theory. Across perception, play, movement, imagination, and social interaction, young children often behave differently from adults. Although these observations are usually treated as independent developmental phenomena, they may instead reflect manifestations of a common underlying control regime. The following observations illustrate how childhood play frequently contains brief suspensions of optimization, a pattern proposed here to resemble the ease regime, hypothesized to permit access to unusually intense and frequent joy. Figure 1 summarizes the central proposal. The following sections develop each component in detail.


Objects
Seen as color, shape, pattern before function.
Stories
Enjoyed in moments, not as a continuous narrative.
Movement
Variable, imperfect, less optimized and more free.
Computer
Exploration over efficiency; trying without a goal.
Sports
Attention to jerseys, ball, and salient features, not strategy.
Social
Expression without self-monitoring or performance pressure.
Imagination
Flexible meanings, easy shifts between real and imagined.
Attention
Drawn to saliencece and immediate features, not utility.
Cartoons
Tolerate non-instrumental content and aimless scenes.
Suspended Optimization
Reduced evaluative control.
Lower next-action pressure.
Ease-like regime
Access to joy, vivid imagination, and positive affective significance of prediction errors.

Figure 1. Childhood Play as Suspended Optimization. Diverse features of childhood behavior, including object perception, imagination, movement, storytelling, social interaction, attraction to cartoons, may reflect a common underlying pattern of suspended optimization. Within the present theory, these observations are interpreted as converging on an ease-like control regime characterized by reduced monitoring and increased access to joy and vivid imagination.

1. Childhood Play as Suspended Optimization

Objects Before Function

Young children often perceive objects and toys primarily in terms of their visual qualities, especially their colors, and shapes. This is particularly true before they fully understand what these objects are for. A toy may first be experienced as an interesting pattern, rather than as something with a specific function. Functional meaning develops progressively, but early perception is dominated by immediate sensory properties.

Imagination Without Commitment

Children also move easily between imagination and ordinary perception. A simple stick can become a Jedi lightsaber, or wizard's staff, carrying rich meaning during play. Yet moments later, the same child may put it back on the ground, where it immediately becomes just an ordinary stick again. The transition often occurs effortlessly. Objects can temporarily recruit powerful imaginative interpretations and then return just as naturally to being ordinary physical objects.

Imagination Without Commitment

Children also appear to tolerate non-instrumental cartoons far more readily than most adults. Scenes that lack a clear objective, coherent narrative, or practical purpose can remain engaging simply because of their colors, characters, or surprising elements. Young children often seem content to experience it as it unfolds. Adults, in contrast, are generally more likely to recruit expectations about plot, meaning, coherence, or purpose, making prolonged engagement with purely aimless content less common.

Movement Before Precision.

Young children's movements are also less optimized than those of adults. They often have only partial control over posture, force, and motor coordination, resulting in movements that are more variable. A child may grasp an object with too much force, or move in ways that appear awkward. Rather than following highly refined motor patterns, their actions retain an element of unpredictability.

Stories Without Narrative Pressure

Children often engage with stories in a way that differs markedly from adults. Following the narrative is not always their primary goal. They may happily watch episodes out of order, forget much of what happened, or revisit the same story repeatedly without concern for continuity. A simple plot can remain enjoyable even if they only partially follow it. Their attention is often drawn just as much to the characters, colors, sounds, emotions, or individual moments as to the overall narrative structure. As a result, complete understanding of the story is not a prerequisite for enjoyment.

Sports Without Strategy

Children also tend to engage with sports differently from adults. Rather than continuously analyzing tactics, rankings, statistics, or the implications of each play, they often attend to immediate features of the event. Their attention may linger on the players' faces, brightly colored jerseys, or especially salient objects such as a yellow or red card. They may have only a limited understanding of the strategic aspects of the game, yet still find the experience engaging. In many cases, enjoyment depends on the immediate sensory qualities of what they are watching.

Exploration Without Efficiency

A child using a computer for the first time also illustrates this mode of interaction. Because the interface is still largely unfamiliar, optimization is naturally suspended. The cursor may first be experienced simply as a moving shape. The child may hesitate between menu items, move the cursor over buttons without clicking, open and close windows for no particular reason, or click on icons simply to see what happens. Unlike an experienced adult, they are less likely to verify every action, or maintain a continuous goal-directed strategy. Their beginner status does not merely place them in a state of discovery, but in a temporary suspension of optimization.

Social Interaction Without Self-Monitoring

Young children also tend to approach social interactions with fewer implicit optimization demands than adults. Before they have fully internalized the social norms of performance, many interactions are simply allowed to unfold. A child may say "hello" without wondering how it was received, speak without carefully selecting the best possible wording, or smile without expecting a particular response. While children gradually learn the complex rules governing social behavior, early interactions are less tightly coupled to self-evaluation optimization.

Captivation Without Purpose

Young children do not even need a game or an activity to become deeply captivated. The smell of a marker, a small shiny metal object, or a simple picture can be enough to hold their attention. Adults, by contrast, are left wondering what mechanism explains the experience.

Therefore, across many everyday domains, adults and children tend to attend to different aspects of the same situation, as show in Figure 2.

Domain	Adult	Child
Objects	Function	Color / Shape
Play	Goal	Exploration
Stories	Narrative	Moments
Sport	Strategy	Jerseys / Ball
Social	Self-monitoring	Expression
Computer	Efficiency	Exploration
Movement	Precision	Variability
Imagination	Stable meaning	Flexible meaning
Attention	Utility	Salience

Figure 2. Comparison of typical adult and childhood modes of engagement across multiple domains. The recurring shift from optimization toward exploration, salience, flexible meaning, and reduced self-monitoring is proposed to reflect a common pattern of suspended optimization.

2. Why Children Rarely Describe It

The claim of high joy in childdhood may be confusing to most adults, because children almost never report joy and high imagination, as it is their normal mode of experience since birth. Rather than thinking, “I feel intense joy,” they experience “it’s recess,” or “it’s Christmas.” The quality of the experience is attributed to the situation, not to the underlying brain state. Only later, as it fades, does it often leave behind a vague nostalgia whose true source is difficult to identify.

Complicating the picture, as people grow older, the sources to which they attribute joy become progressively “heavier.” Joy is then increasingly linked to winning, achieving goals, or consuming preferred forms of entertainment. At the same time, monitoring becomes stronger and increasingly self-justifying. Joy becomes forgotten, dismissed as a myth, or confounded with milder states lacking its intensive and abrupt feature.

3. A Regime Theory of Joy

Within A Regime Theory of Joy, ease is proposed as a permissive control regime. This regime is hypothesized to create the conditions required not only for joy, but also for vivid imagination and an increased subjective sensitivity to prediction errors, a process that has been identified in the literature as a possible contributor to positive affect.

Prediction errors are ubiquitous, appearing in movie cuts, absurd images, unexpected visual transitions, and countless everyday events. If prediction errors alone were sufficient to produce joy, adults should commonly experience the state. Yet children remain disproportionately attracted to useless stimuli. One possible explanation is that prediction errors require access to the ease regime to acquire their affective significance, and that access to this regime becomes progressively restricted during development, as shown below.

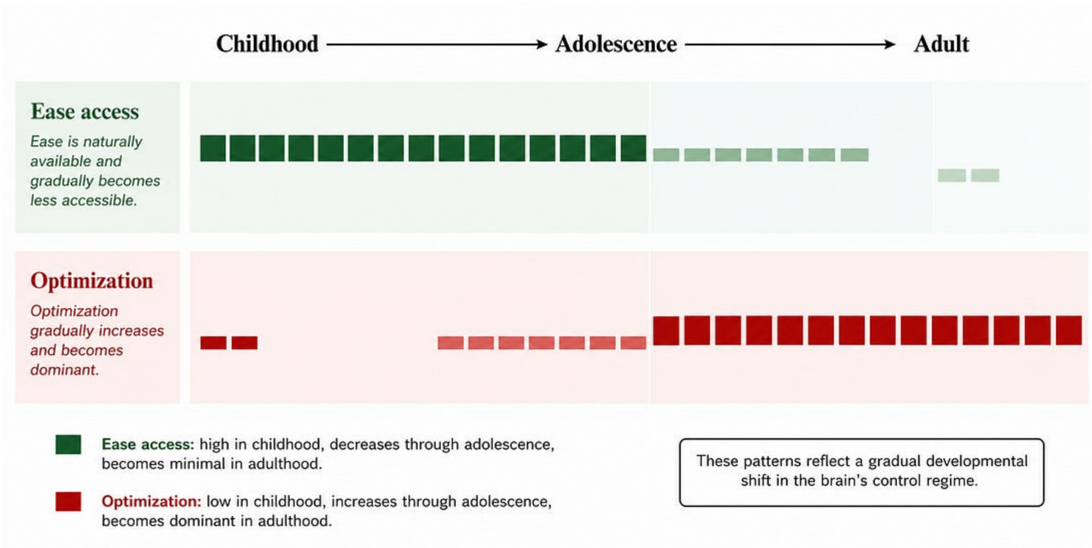

Figure 3. Developmental shift in regimes. Ease access is naturally high during childhood but progressively declines through adolescence, whereas optimization gradually becomes the dominant mode of control in adulthood.

In A Regime Theory of joy, the brain is viewed as operating in multiple control regimes, most of which are accompanied by a degree of intrinsic mental tension. Ease is proposed as the principal exception, the only one compatible with joy. This perspective helps explain why even seemingly neutral activities, such as reading scientific news or simply new information, can produce an unpleasant sense of mental escalation. The central issue is not necessarily suffering itself, but the gradual accumulation of evaluative control, represented here by Z. Z encompasses next action pressure, planning, evaluation, anticipation, verification, and other processes that continuously recruit cognition toward the optimization regime.

4. Practical Implications

Although A Regime Theory of Joy is primarily concerned with describing the proposed ease regime and its properties, it also introduces a set of brief everyday interventions that may help reopen this state. As it is about a regime shift, the tranisition should be sudden and of extremely high intensity, as access is threshold-like. These interventions are collectively referred to as the M-ZRT (Minimal Z-Reduction Task).

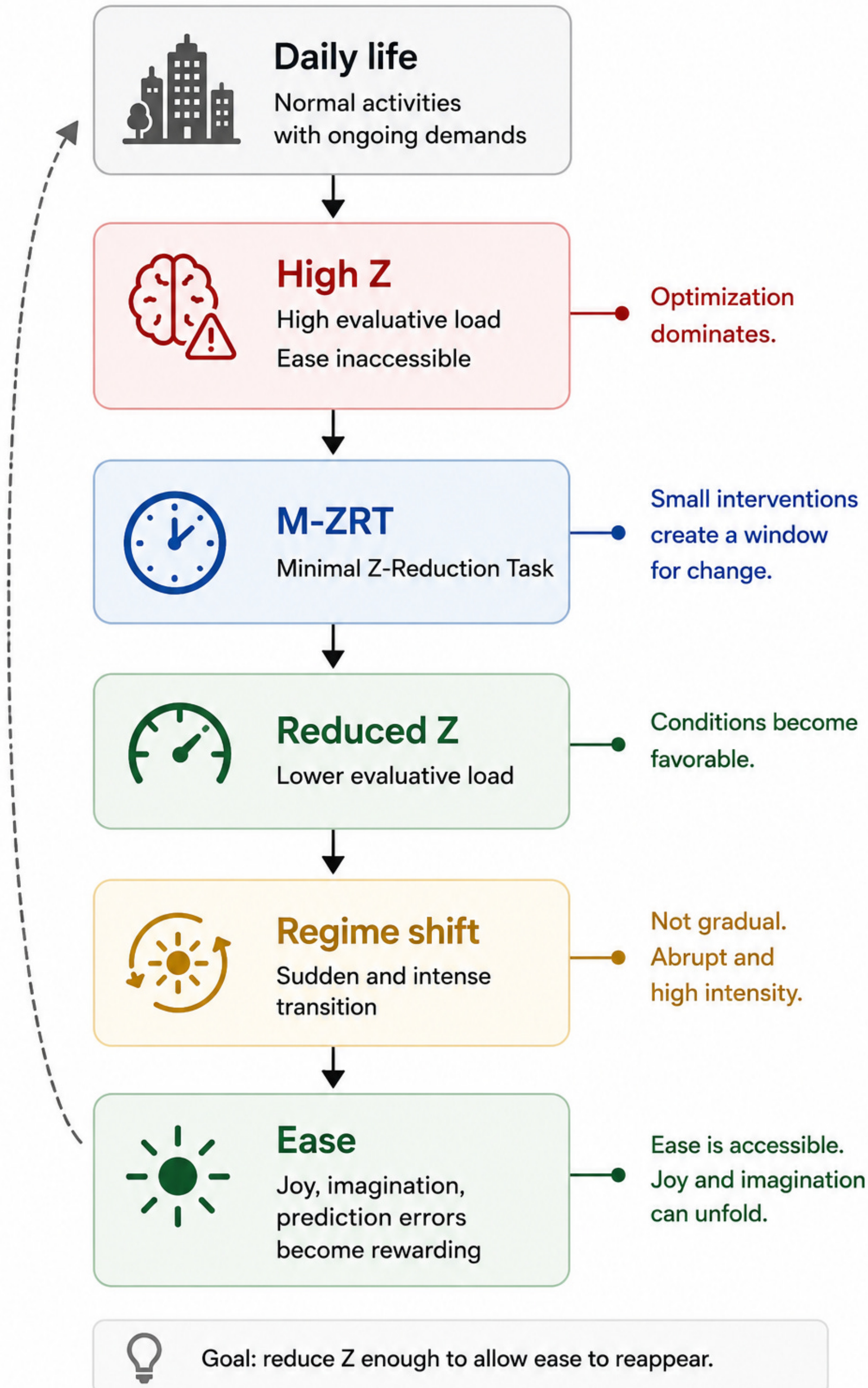
Daily life
Normal activities with ongoing demands
High Z
High evaluative load
Ease inaccessible
Optimization dominates.
M-ZRT
Minimal Z-Reduction Task
Small interventions create a window for change.
Reduced Z
Lower evaluative load
Conditions become favorable.
Regime shift
Sudden and intense transition
Not gradual. Abrupt and high intensity.
Ease
Joy, imagination, prediction errors become rewarding
Ease is accessible. Joy and imagination can unfold.
Goal: reduce Z enough to allow ease to reappear.

Figure 4. Nonlinear transition from optimization to ease. Rather than producing gradual improvement, reductions in evaluative load create the conditions for an abrupt transition into the ease regime.

Informal testing with volunteers is currently underway. If you are interested in trying the current version, you are welcome to contact me by direct message to request a copy.

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.

See florianmorin.com for the papers and more informations.